

If you take the time now to analyze which brokerage firm will best suit your needs, you will save time and frustration later-not to mention the financial cost and potential lost exposure if you switch firms and have to re-brand yourself. Choosing the right brokerage firm from the start means you can focus on building your business.

Start by analyzing your needs. What type of firm is your best fit? Ask yourself these questions:

- What size firm is best for me? (A smaller firm may offer more camaraderie and access to a manager; a larger firm may provide more opportunity to become part of a formal real estate team and interact with a larger number of colleagues.)
- What are the benefits of working for a franchised firm? For a non-franchised firm?
- What kind of office culture is most comfortable for me?
- In what geographic area(s) do I intend to focus my work? (It will make your life easier if the main office, or at least a branch office, is located in the area where you plan to work.)

Do you know any agents? Ask them about their firms and what they recommend that you consider. Then select a few firms that interest you. Research them to identify if they potentially match the needs you identified.

- How long has the firm been in business in your area?
- What's the firm's reputation? Ask around!
- Do you see the firm's yard signs around town?
- Where's the firm's main office? Are there branch offices? Are any of these offices located close to the areas where you want to work or where you live?

Next, schedule an appointment to interview with the broker, a recruiter, or another individual in each firm. Remember, unlike other employers, brokerage firms don't usually advertise that they're looking for salespeople. Instead, they expect salespeople to contact them.